

THE GEORGE DOUGLAS PAPERS

A family reading edition

Volume II

Folder 1: correspondence and loan papers

An independent reading in plain English

Prepared for Volney Douglas

September 2026

Read from the scanned originals. Uncertain words and damaged passages are marked in brackets.

About this volume

This volume is a readable modern-English version of folder 1: correspondence and loan papers. It accounts for every page in the supplied scan, including covers, notes, fragments, and duplicate documents.

Square brackets mark uncertain words, lost passages, and editorial explanations. Page references in the entries count the cover of the source PDF as page 1. The source images, rather than this modernization, remain the basis for settling differences between readings.

The other agent's work was not consulted. Part of the older transcription was seen during initial inventory, before the independent-reading request, then excluded. This is an independent reading in execution, not a blind comparison. See Volume I for the full reading guide and source list.

Use the linked contents, PDF bookmarks, or Word Navigation pane to move between documents. The printed footer numbers belong to this edition; the source-page labels lead back to the scans.

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SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 1

Repository cover

Abilene Christian University, Digital Commons @ ACU. George Douglas Papers, Folder 1: Correspondence and Loan Papers. The repository cover is dated 1939; the individual documents carry their own dates.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 2

A cousin writes from Orange County during the war

Orange County, Texas, June 28, 1864 [date faint]

Cousin George, dear sir,

Having a chance to send you a note, I take pleasure in telling you that I am in good health and fine spirits. Our regiment left Alexandria, Louisiana, a week ago yesterday, for [destination indistinct]. I was detailed to go down Red River and join the command at [Walker's Bend?], but it has not passed. I expect it today. The engine [Sabine?] is laid up, and I cannot leave. Our field [officers?] have not [arrived] yet.

[Name or opening word indistinct] has gone to Ellis on furlough; also [name indistinct]. All are well on furlough. I suppose you have heard of Uncle Alfred's death. He died on May 5 from a wound received on April 18.

The gentleman is waiting for me, and my pen is too bad to write. Please write to me at Houston immediately. Let me know how you are all getting along. If you have [news?], send it [unclear]. I wish I could come and see you, but I cannot leave here.

Yours affectionately,
[J. H.?] Scott

[Several words on this faded page cannot be read confidently.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 3

Address panel

George Douglas, Company C, 6th Texas [remainder of military address unclear]. By Mr. Richardson.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 4-7

Henry's wartime letter: furlough, military duties, and home news

[The folded sheets were scanned out of reading order. The continuous letter below follows page 4, the opening lines of page 5, page 7, page 6, and the remaining text of page 5. Ink showing through from the reverse obscures some phrases.]

[Scan page 4]

Brushy, Ellis County, Texas
Friday, January [29], 1864

Mr. George Douglas—dear cousin,

The heading tells you where I am. After an absence of twenty-one months, I arrived here on the second or third of this month. Since then, I have mingled with the friends of my youth. Truly, I have had a pleasant time. The warm welcome and friendly kindness shown to me have been deeply gratifying.

I have just returned from Aunt Bettie's and thought I would chat with you for a while through this substitute for a visit.

I wrote to you last September but have never learned what became of my letter. Either you did not receive it, or you did not reply. I hope this one will not offend you.

Since last October, I have been on detached service most of the time. Our regiment was sent to the Ouachita River country to gather [men described in the letter as "Yaps"?] for the conscription authorities. I spent two months on this business. Part of my soldiering passed more pleasantly. The first month expired, and [a phrase about provisions is obscured]. As a matter of course, someone who pleases others must please the ladies. In brilliant [evening gatherings], smiles, and [laughter], and where the pot boiled most temptingly, I was not entirely unaware of the gentle sex's influence. On some occasions, I acknowledged their claims.

I admit I found the young ladies of my [district?] attractive—I like to give the devil his due—but [a few connecting words are obscured]. The friends of my acquaintance [unclear] seem to have special claims to superiority. Enough of that, as it is hardly suitable in these times of strife and confusion, when the absorbing theme is war, war: its stern realities and consequences. Our country is now beginning to feel its weight considerably.

[Opening of scan page 5, continuing onto scan page 7]

Now, something about our movements. In the latter part of the fall, a portion of our regiment was sent out to assist the Louisianans in getting men into the service. We all seem to have arrived at the same [time or place]. Colonel Burleson, having become famous as a "Rosinheel" catcher, was sent into this state on the same business. We were mortified to learn that Texas contained quite a number of people of that description.

I joined the command in Rusk County at the end of November. Soon afterward, I volunteered to take some prisoners to Tyler and was then detailed to deliver them at Shreveport. There I was ordered to take some [men or items; unclear] to Bonham. This suited me rather well. I thought the Shreveport commander might object to us visiting home, so we decided to go on to Bonham.

Our company was allowed to spend the holidays in this county. I stayed at home about fifteen days, then reported at Corsicana, and from there was sent to San Augustine. I would prefer not to have anything to do with this business; it is by no means agreeable to me.

Our brigade is ordered to be at Hempstead, Texas, by February 10. It is moving by way of Shreveport. I hope our detachment will be allowed to join it on the march. I leave Monday for the command. At first, I received a twenty-day furlough. Before it expired, I was detailed to transact some business here.

Clothing is being issued to the company every [month?]. I have not drawn a blanket yet. [Irvin?] Lavender, of Ross's regiment, is home on furlough. His squad brought some arms across the [river; word unclear]. [A reference to men under "Copp... Boudy" is obscured.] He reports that the Mississippi army is well supplied and in high spirits.

We have not heard from [Yapett?] and James since the middle of October. [Name unclear] was doing well after the wounds he received in the Chickamauga battle. I am very anxious to know how they came out of the Chattanooga fight.

Captain Bledsoe left Lancaster a few days ago to resume command of his company. That will be gratifying to them, as they were not pleased with the captain placed over them when their command was consolidated.

The last company of the militia has been called out, 200 and more, en route for Galveston. All [460?] were mustered into the service. Those unable to go now have received furloughs lasting from one to six months.

[Scan page 6]

[The opening words are obscured.] The wheat promises very little at present, and I wonder [how people are to live or manage; unclear]. The military authorities are buying [supplies; text obscured]. Our country will undoubtedly suffer this year. [A portion about soldiers and military numbers is illegible.] We confront a large army. What can we do with our scattered battalions?

I am sorry to hear about the dissatisfaction in your battalion. Nothing is more unpleasant to a soldier than to be [oppressed?] and tyrannized over. In this respect, we have done very well. We have enjoyed privileges that the men who enlisted in [other service?] [did not enjoy]. [Several words are obscured.] Monotonous times indeed would be better, and war [unclear] is irksome. But I reckon a person can get used to almost anything, as we are creatures of habit.

Your relatives and friends are enjoying good health. In general, I see no great change in them. The old are looking a little more ancient, while the young have grown [or changed; unclear]. I have suggested that [name unclear] follow in Miss Bettie [L.'s?] footsteps, but she will not agree to it.

The young ladies are looking very well generally. There are too many to speak of individually. I have attended society three Sundays since my arrival. I wish you could have been with me to take a charge, as I could make no show of myself and consequently had to display partiality. Last night, Miss [Ann?] Pett and Mr. Chaffin stayed with us until midnight, and [Miss Emma?] [name or phrase obscured].

Since I came home, I have availed myself of an opportunity to see [name unclear] and spent the night in the colony. I was at Mr. [G.'s?] last evening. Miss Ellen and Laura were there. My company were going to a party at Richardson's last night. I told them I would like to go with them but excused myself, as I cared nothing for the party. [A sentence about meeting someone and spending a pleasant evening is obscured.]

[The writer notes that it is now 2 p.m. and continues on the other sheet.]

[Remaining text of scan page 5]

George, I have heard that you have a very fine hat. I have one I would like to swap with you, so if you wish to [trade], I agree on condition that we exchange [by letter?]. I do not think I could make much of it; perhaps you can [unclear]. Cousin Lizzie came home with us and has now received a letter that appears to have come from beyond the [Mississippi?].

Well, George, I called on two young ladies whom I think were rather interested in you. During the interview, I took occasion to speak of you in glowing terms, which seemed to hold a great deal of meaning for them. I am justified in saying that you may have no fears: all will be well for you [unclear] your admirers.

As this page is devoted to subjects that are pleasant and winning, I will tell you that I have been a subject of general remark since my arrival. If there is anything in reports, I have been married to two ladies here in the county and stand in line for another nearby. I should think that if I am charged with so many good things, I must have something from them.

[About] eight days ago, I managed to tell one that I wished the reports were true, but she tossed her lip and replied, "I don't." I was rather taken aback. I was not aware of being so popular. Probably it is the bracing air, don't you think?

By the way, I notice that many of the officers of Bragg's army have been married [a comparison with the Confederation of the fifteen-to-one odds is indistinct]. I expect to hear of the fall of the ladies next. If so, I think it will be a [good opportunity?] to raise a regiment, and I wish you to be my chief of staff. What do you think of the arrangement?

A corporal's guard came to my [quarters?] yesterday. I could have made up a company. [Words about the ladies and Miss Mollie are obscured.] They think the whole arrangement a fine one. I promised them influence on condition that they would [enlist?]. I must conclude, as my thoughts are fleeting and frail. [Closing sentence obscured.] Give my love to [name unclear], with the assurance that you will divide it between [names unclear], and be careful to return an ample amount yourself.

Address me at Hempstead, Texas, Company H, Brown's Regiment.

Your cousin,
Henry

[Upside-down postscript at the top of scan page 5]

Saturday the 30th: Cousin Lizzie, Sister, and I expect to go to Lancaster tomorrow to hear Brother Carlton. If the weather is favorable and [unclear] presents itself, I will not stay long. Have you a [reply?] for me?

Henry

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 8-9

Loose fragments of the wartime correspondence

[These are small, damaged pieces with writing in both directions. They are not complete letters. They may belong to the preceding letter, but their precise positions are uncertain.]

[Scan page 8]

"[Colonel?] [name lost] has [come?]..."; "...a [brigadier?] in the service..."; "...will be called [commander?]..."

"...all matters [now?] ... to settle at the [end?]."

"...down [unclear] ... I spent the evening ... I took a peep at your 'shadow' [a likeness or photograph], which looks [unclear]. Read some poetical contributions ... [a] brain ... its fruitful imagination ..."

[Scan page 9]

"There has been considerable [stirring?] and quibbling, but they all have to go if the emergency is such..."

“...then the clothing affair ... [wearing?] a cotton waist ... You have been deprived of [unclear], but do not explain the actual [circumstances?]. There is my [friend?] who also [unclear] ... I thought of returning them to you ... [the remaining words are obscured].”

[A smaller piece has only disconnected words, including “girl,” “your,” and “pleasant.” The lost passages cannot be reconstructed from these fragments.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 10–11

Henry offers sympathy and reports from camp

Camp [Waverly?], Texas

March 13, 1865

Cousin George, dear sir,

I acknowledge your kind letter of the twelfth. It stirred many pleasant feelings, especially the part about our association in years gone by. While enjoying these times over again in imagination and reflecting on the return of a long-absent mother, I was saddened by news of your sister's death.

All look forward with mingled feelings of gladness and sorrow to the end of trying scenes such as these. In this dark hour of bereavement, you have my sympathy. No longer can you look to her cheerful, homelike presence. [A short connecting phrase is unclear.] The fluttering of hope is overtaken by the cold reality. By it, we are warned that we are mortal. Let us use these finer feelings of our nature for our comfort and in the performance of our duty.

[Scan page 11]

We are all well here and continue to have agreeable times. We came to this place on March 8 and will very likely go to the Brazos country. I suppose the forage in this section will be exhausted in ten days or two weeks.

[George B.'s?] arrival was very unexpected to me. I had greatly feared he had not survived the Tennessee campaign. Through him, I heard a letter from Brother James, which I enclose to you.

Lafayette wants to transfer to this department. Mr. Browne of this company wants to transfer to Lafayette's command and has written to Captain [Ward?] on the subject. The captain will make an effort to arrange it. Nothing could give me more heartfelt pleasure.

I am looking for [Tayett?] and Lumber [Rea?] within a few days. We recently heard from Aunt Bettie. She was quite sick.

Address me at Hempstead, which is [our post-office address?].

Much love to you, and goodbye.

Your cousin,

Henry

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 12–14

“The River of Death,” copied for Lizzie

[Scan page 14 labels this a ballad, “The River of Death,” written for Lizzie. The accompanying note says it was copied, so this does not establish that Henry composed it. The poem below preserves all seven stanzas in modernized language.]

[Scan page 12]

Beautiful world! I trusted you for so long—
Your glittering show, your siren song.
I thought the joy you gave would last,
But one by one, those joys rushed past,
Until the last you could give has flown,
And I stand by the river, alone! Alone!

I was merry once; to music sweet,
I kept time with my dancing feet.
I crowned my hair with roses red,
But the lute is broken, the roses dead.
Music and flowers have long since gone,
And I stand by the river, alone! Alone!

And once I loved—it was a dream of bliss.
Could earth give her child more than this?
Such rapture that it was almost pain,
A garland of flowers, a silken chain.
But love, like a vision at night, has flown,
And I stand by the river, alone! Alone!

[Scan page 13]

Then madly I drank from the cup of fame,
And smiled when thousands praised my name.
My song was heard with wonder and awe,
But quickly it faded and drifted away.
Leaf after leaf, until all were gone,
And I stand by the river, alone! Alone!

And what have I done, O Christ, for you?
Draw back the veil from my dim eyes!
Have I given a cup of cold water
To one little lamb in your precious fold?
The time for work is past and gone,
And I stand by the river, alone! Alone!

O Christ, have mercy! The wild waters
Are sweeping away your wandering child.
Will you not listen? Oh, take my hand,
And guide me through to the distant land.
All that I trusted on earth has flown.
Must I sink in the river, alone! Alone!

The river! The river! It is dark and wide,
But I see a light on the other side.
My heart no longer is faint with fear,
For sorrow has passed; my Lord is near.
With joyful steps I hurry on,
No more in the river, alone! Alone!

[Accompanying note on scan page 13]

Blossomdale, July 6, [1875?]

Cousin Lizzie,

You thought the few lines above, which I repeated on the night of the fourth, were beautiful. To indulge my inclination to scribble, I have written out a copy for you, trusting that you will receive it gladly. I think the lines are very beautiful. They are doubtless the work of some famous [writer; final word unclear].

Your cousin,
Henry

To Lizzie.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 15

Damaged address panel

Long Prairie, April [16; year torn away]. To Mr. [Horeb?] Sharp, Nashville, Milam County, Texas. [Only part of the cover survives.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 16

Cover addressed to Lizzy Douglas

Miss Lizzy Douglas, Red Oak Post Office, Texas. The surviving postmark reads “[Nashville?], Texas, Ap[ril...].” [The remainder is torn away.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 17-18

Henry writes from home about court, a camp meeting, and the war

[Willow Branch?], Texas
September [18], 1864

Cousin George,

I have written several times but have received only silence. Perhaps my uncertain whereabouts are the cause, for I cannot think you so ungenerous as not to have written since I left last January. Sometimes I have thought my letter of last spring contained something unacceptable. If so, I cannot imagine what it was, for if you are like most soldiers, your feelings could hardly be ruffled.

I will give you another shot. If silence is again the response, I will know something is wrong in Denmark and call off my hounds. As I am floating in a rather dull atmosphere, I cannot promise to be very interesting. Still, I hope to relieve your camp's monotony for a while.

I am home on detail to get clothing for our company. I arrived last Saturday evening. Things in this neighborhood are much as they were before the war, except for the absence of the young men. Plenty seems to smile at every door. Were it not for the absent ones, I think people here could scarcely believe a great war was wreaking havoc on their countrymen.

I have visited very little yet. I have been to Waxahachie twice. An important case is before the district court: the murder of Mrs. Clement by her daughter. [This is the writer's description of the charge, not an independently established finding.] The case has not yet been decided, but from the evidence I have heard, I believe she will be acquitted, though not considered innocent by the public.

On Monday, I went from Waxahachie to the Red Oak campground, where a camp meeting was underway, and stayed until Tuesday. Attendance was smaller than in former years, especially among the sterner sex, but there was no lack on the other side. The soldiers present received marked attention. I enjoyed those provisions that keep soul and body together, but I did not work hard to make myself agreeable or to spread what is sometimes called a fluttering of the heart. My observations suggest that the germs of that malady lie dormant and only need sunshine to grow strong and catching.

There were shouting times that night, though some things went the other way. Some sorrowful mourners were there, including a soldier friend who yielded to the urging of an old gentleman who had long pressed his claims upon him.

If shouting measures goodness, I think this meeting's standing is rather poor. It certainly contains the most impudent [or "profane"; word unclear] collection I have met. Perhaps this is partly due to the abundance of preachers, who claim exemption because of their calling and fear that unless they all preach, they will have to shoulder their muskets and fight the enemy. [These are the writer's opinions.]

[Scan page 18]

I will now tell you something of our command's operations. In June it was [in the west of Louisiana; the precise place is obscured]. A week or so later, [a name or unit is illegible] returned to the valley of Red River. We remained in that state for a month, mostly on [bayous?]. About August 1, we moved to the Mississippi Valley near Natchez. We stayed there a couple of weeks and were then ordered to our former field, Arkansas.

On August 31, the brigade started upriver. We had "seen the elephant" in Louisiana [experienced combat], and the boys were willing to go anywhere. They will doubtless see some other large animal in Arkansas, for they will have to find it if they expect [several crossed-out or obscured words]. I hope the boys will all get home by [the time is unclear]. They will have plenty of work with Steele. Major's men have also gone [destination or assignment unclear]. Walker's and Polignac's [forces are mentioned; connecting words obscured]. If so, you may live to hear of stirring times this fall.

While scouting along the Mississippi, our squadron turned over about thirty fine horses, with their equipment, to the Yankees. About half the men went down to New Orleans to get some crackers. The others escaped by running and hiding in the weeds. They were completely surprised at about three in the morning on August 28. Several were wounded and captured, but none were killed. Captain Veal was away from his command. He and the dismounted men are now at home getting new mounts. I was not in the scrape.

Jef and some of my mess, who lost their horses, had just come out on leave. Rob got to camp the day before I left. I had chills for about a month during the summer, was sick last evening, and expect them to return. Jephtha was down last week.

[Names unclear] and Lizzie [went or joined us] Sunday, with [names unclear]. Emma spent last night here. Brother has had a very sick girl; she is getting [better?]. We had a fine rain the day before yesterday. Parson Austin called in today on his way back from the meeting. It is still going on. Brother [McCamp?] has been indisposed, with only seven professions [of faith] so far.

We recently received a letter from Lafayette, dated the second of this month. Their brigade had a heavy fight on July 22. Their regiment entered the battle with 138 men and came out with about 80 [figures somewhat unclear]. James was wounded through the wrist and hand and was in hospital. Those of their company not killed had to surrender, while they were attacking [the] camps. Fayette threw down his [gun?] and ran out. He was still in good health.

My sheet is full. I hope to hear from you before I leave for the army.

Yours truly,
H. Douglas

[A few marginal words are too obscured to recover.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 19–20

Bob remembers hunting with George

Cold Springs, Texas
February 19, 1863

Mr. George Douglas—dear cousin,

You may think it strange to receive a letter from me, as you have probably forgotten your old hunting companion and schoolmate. It has been a long time since we used to meet down on old Brushy and take a shot at the old gobblers. I fear it will be longer still before we enjoy that blessed privilege again.

Nearly four years have passed since I saw you. I imagine you are the same old George you used to be. I have not changed, except from big to bigger. I weigh 175 pounds and am the biggest devil in the company.

This morning, I was ordered to report to brigade headquarters for fatigue duty. I went halfway, turned around, and came back. Now I am watching for the guard to arrest me. If they do, I will lie my way out somehow.

We are having a very pleasant time at this camp. Duty is easy: we drill an hour every day except Sunday, as before. We also have a chain of guards around the camp who will not let a fellow out with his saddle. You ought to see the boys riding off across the country bareback.

There is a big religious meeting in camp. About forty mourners were there last night. They have not got me yet, but I do not know how soon they will, for every time the old fellow preaches, I feel a lump in my throat as big as your fist.

[Scan page 20]

I have not heard from my brothers east of the Mississippi for two or three months. I fear they are having a hard time.

I will bring this badly composed letter to a close. Give my respects to all my friends.

As ever, your cousin,

[initials unclear]

P.S. Write and give me all the news. Tell me how you like the war and when you think it will end.

Bob

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 21-24

James describes his wounded hand and hopes of coming home

Tupelo, Mississippi

January 25, 1865

Dear brother,

Brother Lafayette will leave for home on furlough in a few days, so I will write a few lines to let you know how I am getting along.

I was painfully wounded on July 22 while charging the enemy's works. The ball struck my left wrist and passed through my hand. The wrist bones were badly fractured, as was the bone of my middle finger. I have suffered a great deal. Around the middle of August, I caught a fever. For two months, I was hardly able to get off my bunk without help.

In October, I received sixty days' furlough to visit our relatives in Mobile. When I reached Demopolis, my hand was hurting badly and I was very unwell. I decided to stop for a few days until I improved. I stayed with an old lady named Brassfield. There, I received all the attention a Confederate soldier could wish for. By the time I was well enough to go on, I had decided to end my journey there rather than go to Mobile [the sentence crosses a damaged edge].

[Scan page 22]

I spent the time very pleasantly and only regretted that I could not stay longer. I shall never forget the kind people of Alabama.

When my furlough expired, I set off for the command. Learning that I could not reach it, I changed direction and went to Columbus, Mississippi, intending to extend my furlough and go on to Mobile. Before I could leave, the Federals destroyed the railroad, preventing me from getting there. I went into the hospital and remained until a few days ago.

My hand has still not healed. The wounds closed on both sides until each opening was about the size of a pea, but they have healed no further. They drain all the time. The doctors say this is caused by diseased bone, or by pieces of bone that ought to have been removed. My wrist will be entirely stiff. I think I will be able to use all my fingers except the middle one.

I returned to the command last week and found the boys in good health. Very few of our brigade are left: only about four hundred out of five regiments.

[Scan page 23; its top strip repeats the opening of page 21]

Only four men in old Company I are left who are fit for duty. One in every seven is being furloughed to go to Texas. Brother Lafayette gets seventy-five days' leave to go home. I am glad he can go and would very much like to accompany him. But I cannot do so honorably, and I would not go home any other way.

I hope you will see Lafayette; he can tell you all the news. I would dearly like to go home. I tried to get a furlough but failed. I shall try to get on the retired list, as I am unfit for field service. If I succeed, I think I will get home by next fall. Even if retired, I would only stay home for nine months. I do not think I would remain there as long as Lafayette is in this army. We have been together all the time, and I think I ought to stay with him. If he became sick or wounded, I would be here to help.

[Scan page 24; its top strip repeats part of page 22]

Lafayette has just returned from the 10th Texas. Squire gets a furlough too. They intended to travel together, but Squire will not get away for a few days, and Lafayette wants to start tomorrow, so they will probably not go together. I will travel with [Lafayette; the original says "you"] as far as Meridian.

I have not heard lately from our cousins, the Jetton boys. Tip is in prison. Billy and Charly were well when last heard from. The 6th Texas boys were all well too.

It is very cold, and I am nearly smoked to death, so I will close for now. Please excuse this hasty, badly written letter. I will try to do better in future. Remember my compliments to all the boys and accept my best wishes for yourself. Write often, and I will do the same. Hoping that we may soon meet again, I remain your true brother,

James [middle initial and surname unclear]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 25

Envelope from George to Zella

From Geo. Douglas, Red Oak, Texas. To Zella Douglas, 1715 Grand Avenue, North Fort Worth, Texas. Two-cent United States postage. Red Oak postmark; date partly indistinct.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 26

Note on the back of the envelope

"Met today Ann Conger, now Mrs. Smithson, Eva's old playmate at Ferris."

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 27–28

George tells Zella about the Sylvana meeting

Monday morning

Dear Zella,

Of course, you would like to know about the meeting. Although there have been no further additions, yesterday was a big day. As announced, there was dinner on the grounds—and what a dinner! About the finest ever spread at Sylvana.

Among the visitors were White Stirman and his wife, who sends her love to you, and Nellie Ransdell. They left for Ennis after last night's preaching. White and his family are moving right away to Marlin, where he has a job running a Watkins medicine wagon.

Three carloads came from Oak Cliff. Among them were G. H. Barclay, who kindly remembered you; the wife of J. C. Estes, the preacher; Brother Stevens's mother, wife, and sister; Brother Melton and his family; and Brother Holsenback and his wife.

[Scan page 28]

They thoroughly enjoyed themselves and repeatedly invited me to visit when I am in Dallas. Mrs. Dr. Mitchell and her family, and Brother Dunn's family, came from Waxahachie. These were most of the visitors who stayed for dinner.

After dinner, Mrs. Howard and her family arrived and stayed until after the evening preaching. Everyone who knew her from her time with us showered her with attention. Last came Cliff Stanford, much to his many friends' delight.

The meeting may close tonight or perhaps tomorrow night. Brother Dunn, being something of a revivalist, is discouraged by his work here. He is disappointed.

There is no change in Lucile's condition. I expect to finish this letter at Red Oak this evening and give you the latest news. Larkin is much worse. His disease took a dangerous turn the day before yesterday. I will hear about him this morning. All visitors have been forbidden. The outlook is very serious.

[No closing appears on this sheet. The following sheets include further family and meeting news, but their exact relationship to this letter is not certain.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 29–30

Crop failure and more news for Zella

[The first surviving line begins mid-letter. August 11 is mentioned, but no year is visible.]

We will have to cut expenses. As of today, August 11, the Ellis County cotton crop is a failure. Worms have completely destroyed all the bolls and buds, and blooms are scarcer than I have ever seen. If anything is produced, it must develop later; there is nothing now. The worms are of every size, which suggests they will be with us for some time yet.

I hope you continue to do well, gain weight and strength, and keep both. I am feeling fine. Looking after myself agrees with me, although I am not particularly fond of it. I am getting two to eight eggs a day.

At Kate's, I found Lucile [a few words are too faint]. She seems quite unwell and is suffering considerably. Kate says, "Her stomach has gone back on her." Poor child, she looks bad. Larkin is about the same. [A faint note marked Saturday expresses hope that he will pull through; several words cannot be recovered.]

[Scan page 30 begins with the end of a sentence]

"...sermon to the church today." Ida Duncan and May Fair made their confession and will be baptized this evening. The meeting will close tomorrow night.

I came up today and had a really civilized dinner with Brother Duncan. I do not see why all women cannot cook; it is so much nicer.

Jesse Ligon and his family have returned to Red Oak, bag and baggage. I am glad they are back, as Jess is the best Ligon of the whole bunch. Did I tell you that the old wooden center of Red Oak burned out from brick to brick? Well, the old rat traps are gone. Some people lost heavily.

That brings the news up to date.

Affectionately,
G. D.

Do the best you can for yourself while you are there. Do not worry about me. My peach preserves were highly praised.

[An upside-down fragment along the bottom reads, "...some of everything is needed; it had the..." Its continuation is not identifiable.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 31

Another envelope for Zella

From Geo. Douglas, Red Oak, Texas. To Zella Douglas, 1715 Grand Avenue, North Fort Worth, Texas. Two-cent postage; Red Oak postmark with an indistinct date.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 32-33

George's troublesome tire and news from home

Wednesday evening

Dear Zella,

I have just received your letter. I stayed with Clarence and Kate Sunday night and saw you through the car window as you passed Monday morning.

I came home that evening. Today I went back for the laundry and the young lady. I had a puncture coming home and got very hot and dirty repairing it. After taking the young lady home, I had gone only a few hundred yards on my return when the same tire went flat again. What a time I had! Some men came along, but together we still could not repair it. I drove to Rockett on the rim, and Sid Farrar soon helped me put it right.

I then spent three hours with Kate. The children certainly look bad. Glenn was unwell, but Kate looks much better than I expected.

[Scan page 33]

They will have to give up that place on August 1. They will probably move to Roland's house in the pasture.

I opened the letter to you from Paris to see whether it should be forwarded. You will find it enclosed. I will send your letter to Aunt Nannie by way of explanation.

I do hope your appetite stays with you and that the girls attend to your needs. Do not be a burden, and do not overdo things. Do not worry about me. Yesterday evening I boiled two potatoes and six eggs. Ruth gave me a glass of plum jelly. I have plenty of bread, and I reboiled the molasses and strained it through the new sifter. I am all prepared to get fat.

Elmer Carter is very glad to get all [the benefit] of the cow. There has been plenty of rain since you left. Tell Edwina I enjoyed reading her good letter enormously.

Affectionately,
G. D.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 34-35

George manages the house; Olaf is gravely ill

Tuesday morning ["Monday" is crossed out]

Dear Zella,

Your Sunday letter arrived yesterday. I am glad you did not have a bad time last week and hope this week will be better. I know Ed's expenses must be enormous, but make sure you do not add to them.

Our housekeepers packed their goods Saturday, loaded two wagons Sunday evening, and left Monday morning for Bartlett, Texas. They shipped their belongings at Waxahachie and should have arrived by now.

So my prospects of keeping house for myself grow brighter every day. Certainly, I live better, and my next cook must look refined. My nieces cannot understand why I insist on staying home. There is not much reason for it, except that I dislike leaving the house empty at night.

Elmer Carter has taken the cow to his house. There is nothing left for me to do except gather a very few eggs in the evening.

[Scan page 35]

The hens are mostly on strike. They mainly drink at a swampy spring just below the feterita patch, and the feterita [a sorghum crop] gives them plenty to eat.

Our meeting crowds are small, and the preaching is not much bigger. This noticeably irritates Brother Dunn, but he has a poor way of helping himself. Building a large audience is a big job. The crowds will probably grow later.

Word came last night that Olaf wished to be baptized. Brother Duncan immediately returned to Red Oak to prepare. Brother Dunn and others went up after church to attend to it. I have had no word from them by this writing.

Dr. Slaten told the friends that Olaf apparently has only a few days to live. This is hard on Kate, though not unexpected. Lucile can sit in a rocking chair for an hour or so each day. I will finish after I hear more from them.

At Kate's, Tuesday evening: Olaf is resting fairly well now. He looks bad and is very emaciated. Plenty of friends are here, which reassures them that they are not being neglected. I see no change in Lucile.

Affectionately,
G. D.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 36–37

Olaf's death and burial

Thursday morning

Dear Zella,

Olaf died yesterday evening at 6:30. I am just about to go up there. I spent a couple of hours there yesterday morning. They had all the outside help needed for their comfort.

Lucile is still able to sit up for a little while each day.

Larkin has blood poisoning. I spent a couple of hours there yesterday evening. It began when a hen scratched his thumb a few days ago. The thumb became inflamed and very painful. That improved somewhat, but now he has a large red spot on the top of his right foot, with red streaks running nearly to his knee. He has some fever but is not suffering much.

Mrs. Wadley, the doctor's mother, died yesterday evening.

[Scan page 37]

Red Oak, Thursday evening

I have just returned from Olaf's burial at Rawlins Cemetery. Many friends and sympathizers were present. Brother Dunn gave a good, comforting talk at the tabernacle. It was very hot, but I stood it fairly well.

I cannot yet say how the death and funeral will affect Lucile. She seems to have considerable strength and may linger for quite a while.

Hattie Stanford is to be baptized this evening. Quite a number of people came down today from Patrick Chapel, and many are expected from Oak Cliff on Sunday. I hope you are doing well this week.

Affectionately,
G. D.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 38

George to Zella: peach preserves and potatoes

Thursday morning

Dear Zella,

I am still keeping house by myself and doing fine. I do not expect my housekeepers back soon.

Mary Roberts sent down and got all the fruit jars she wanted some days ago. Edna came yesterday evening and got seventeen for her mother.

I gathered peaches from the tree up by the Mustang vine and put up a gallon and a quart of preserves all by myself. I used twelve pounds of peaches and nine pounds of sugar. I began at sunup and finished at noon, without adding a drop of water.

I have sold thirteen dollars' worth of potatoes and still have plenty left. Kate and the children are doing as well as could be expected. There is nothing new.

Affectionately,
G. D.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 39

Envelope addressed to C. C. Douglas, 1941

To Mr. C. C. Douglas, 212 East University, Waxahachie, Texas.

Return address: Suite 1614, 100 East 42nd Street, New York.

Postmarked New York, February 28, 1941; six cents postage paid. [This date falls outside the date range in the collection title. It is retained as shown on the envelope.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 40

Bruce Headrick's \$1,000 commissioner's loan, January 27, 1939

Federal Land Bank of Houston, Division of Commissioners' Loans. Application 189 553; loan 536 394J. Borrower: Bruce Headrick, Red Oak, Texas; Ellis association.

The first payment, \$7.00 for interest only, is due April 1, 1939. Later payments are due each October 1 and April 1. The note is dated January 11, 1939, with a ten-year term.

This is a second-lien loan. The land description refers to the accompanying Federal Land Bank papers rather than repeating the details here.

Distribution: check 341 819, payable to the association and Bruce Headrick and Zella Douglas, \$1,000. Total loan: \$1,000.

The closing must follow the bank's general instructions and its letter of January 11, 1939. Special requirement 3: pay the balance of the purchase-money lien; see the Federal Land Bank papers.

Attorney: Thos. F. White. The borrower's approval, date, and secretary-treasurer's attestation spaces are blank. The lower-left office notation includes Ellis and Wm. J. Mills.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 41

Bruce Headrick's \$1,800 Federal Land Bank loan, January 27, 1939

Federal Land Bank of Houston. Application 189 553; loan 92 466J. Borrower: Bruce Headrick, Route 1, Red Oak, Texas; Ellis National Farm Loan Association.

First payment: \$11.03 for interest only, due April 1, 1939 [the date is corrected by hand]. This covers interest from the voucher date to the start of the first amortization period. Interest between the note date and voucher date has already been rebated.

Regular payments: \$66.60 every April 1 and October 1. Payments must reach the association's secretary-treasurer in time for the bank's due date. R. D. Johnson, treasurer.

Security: seventy acres in Ellis County, A. J. Porter survey, abstract 829.

Distribution of the \$1,800 loan: eighteen shares at five dollars each, \$90, deducted for association stock; balance of loan fee, \$7; check 341 818 payable to the secretary-treasurer and Zella Douglas, \$1,703.

Closing requirements: execute, record, and return the transfer and assignment; total debt secured by the property must not exceed \$2,800; provide certificates showing all state, county, school, special, and other taxes paid through 1938; comply with the January 11, 1939 instructions. Attorney: Thos. F. White. Total application charges for the Federal Land Bank and commissioner's loans: \$17. The borrower's approval spaces are blank.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 42-45

The heirs release claims to one another's shares of N. L. Douglas's estate, 1875

Texas, Ellis County, February 19, 1875.

We, the undersigned heirs of N. L. Douglas, acknowledge that our mother, Mary Douglas, has separately deeded portions of the estate to us. In exchange for the portions each of us has received, we bind ourselves, our heirs, and our assigns to give up permanently all claims against one another's portions of the estate. Each of us releases all estate property except the part individually deeded to that person. We sign and acknowledge this agreement before the proper authorities.

Signatures: Jesse Douglas; George Douglas; Lizzie Douglas; Laura Robinson; Thos. J. Robinson; Susanna Bell; J. M. Bell; J. W. Douglas; Warren Douglas [the last signature is partly hidden by the fold].

[Scan pages 42-44 overlap: the acknowledgment is photographed more than once.]

Ellis County acknowledgment: George Douglas, Lizzie Douglas, W. Douglas, Thos. J. Robinson, and J. M. Bell appeared and acknowledged that they had executed the quitclaim deed for its stated purposes. Laura Robinson, wife of Thos. J. Robinson, and Susanna Bell, wife of J. M. Bell, were questioned privately, apart from their husbands. Both said that they had signed freely, without force, fear, or improper persuasion, and did not wish to withdraw their consent.

Certified February 26, 1875, by Wm. L. Hancock, notary public, Ellis County, Texas, precinct 3. Certificate 76.

Hood County acknowledgment: Jesse Douglas personally acknowledged signing and delivering the quitclaim deed for its stated purposes and said that he did not wish to withdraw it. Certified at Glen Rose, March 9, 1875, by W. L. [McCormick?], notary public, Hood County, Texas.

[Scan page 45]

Docket: the Douglas heirs to Mary Douglas; deed. Filed August 21, 1875, at 10:30 a.m.; J. M. Phillips, clerk of the district court. Recorded in deed record O, pages 2 and 3. Recording certificate: August 23, 1875, at 9 a.m., Waxahachie; J. M. Phillips, clerk, by H. C. Wise, deputy. The docket also notes eighty-five cents, apparently the recording charge.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 46

Survey description of Bruce Headrick's seventy acres

Seventy acres in the A. J. Porter survey, abstract 829, Ellis County, Texas.

Begin at an iron stake at the northwest corner of Miss Zella Douglas's property, on the south line of George Douglas's eighty-acre tract (deed records, volume Z, page 58) and at the northeast corner of J. H. Hedrick's twenty acres (volume 179, page 362).

Follow these survey lines. Bearings and distances are retained in their original form; "varas" is the survey unit used in the document.

- N 60° E, along the south line of the eighty acres, 625 varas to a stake.
- S 30° E, 587 varas to the center of Brushy Creek.
- Up the center of the creek: S 61 $\frac{3}{4}$ ° W, 55 varas; S 13 $\frac{1}{4}$ ° W, 78; S 49 $\frac{3}{4}$ ° W, 99; S 73 $\frac{3}{4}$ ° W, 25; N 48° W, 65.5; S 64 $\frac{3}{4}$ ° W, 61.5; S 73 $\frac{3}{4}$ ° W, 63; S 29° W, 91; S 14° W, 54.5; S 18 $\frac{3}{4}$ ° E, 60.5; S 51° W, 42; S 87 $\frac{3}{4}$ ° W, 93, reaching the west line of Zella Douglas's property.
- N 30° W, along that west line, 680 varas to the starting point.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 47-52

Papa to Zella: treatment in Union City, September 3, 1923

[Scan page 47 is a torn envelope or wrapper marked "Sept 3—Union City" and "Zella." The letter begins on page 48, upside down in the scan.]

Union City, September 3, 1923

My dear child,

Your very brown letter has just arrived. With a magnifying glass I managed to read most of it. Please use ink, or rough paper that a pencil will mark.

I want one hundred dollars for the Ford, with no trade. That hundred dollars would pay for your trip here if you should come. Sell the young cattle, because keeping them through winter will not pay. Put up feed for just one cow. Pay the taxes, and have Ligon attend to the note due at the Waxahachie bank on September 11. Look over my letters and follow the instructions.

[Scan page 49]

I do not know when I will get to come home. From present prospects, I would say not before November 1. This last problem is, if anything, worse than the first. A large lump came out through my cheek, and another, smaller one is to follow. I see no chance of the hole healing before November. I am not suffering so much now, but it has been very bad. I get about eighteen hours of ease out of every twenty-four.

[Scan page 50]

What I fear is that more metastases may develop. The radium scattered the trouble into my cheek in such small particles that they will take time to develop. So it is impossible to say yet whether all of them have been caught. This last will be the fourth one treated, and I would be glad to know it was the last.

I specified all the clothing I want; do not send any more.

[Scan page 51]

Do not send them in a suitcase. Roll them tightly, sew cloth around them, wrap them in brown paper, and send them by insured parcel post. That is the cheapest and best way.

Please read my letters and follow the instructions. Get a close estimate of the crop. You may have to come out here, and the trip will take a hundred dollars. I want all debts at home paid so that I can decide what is best to do.

A trip here will wear you out and get on your nerves. I do not know whether you could stand it, so be ready.

[Scan page 52]

If you have to come, bring warm clothing; it is cooler here than in Texas. Well-cooked half-moon pies and sandwiches like those you prepared for me make excellent traveling food. A tin cup for water is indispensable.

No, I cannot return by way of Nashville. I would not risk the altitude over the Cumberland Mountains. I am glad [Anna?] stopped to see you. I hope and know that you will make her visit pleasant. My appetite remains good, and I sleep well.

Affectionately,

Papa

[The description of illness and treatment is the writer's account, preserved here without adding a modern diagnosis.]

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 53-54

Papa: “Your company is that much more precious”

[An additional two-page note following the September 3 letter; no date is visible.]

I would love for you to be here. I get very blue and lonely at times, and you are all I have that is best to live for. At my age I cannot remain here long, so your company is that much more precious.

I may survive this trouble, or I may not. Either way, my physical strength will be greatly reduced. That is why I wanted the car sold: my days of cranking a car are over.

[Scan page 54]

I ask only that you get the business into good order. Know how much money is on hand, how much more is likely to come in, and what expenses must be met. Then, if we think it best, you can visit me. You would not get much from the people here; they are not your sort.

Allie leaves tomorrow for [Gunter?] to run a dormitory. I am staying with Dr. Bird.

Papa

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 55–60

Papa to Zella: feeling better, September 6 [1923]

[Scan page 55: envelope addressed to Zella Douglas, Red Oak, Texas; Union City, California postmark, September 7, 1923. The letter is headed "Thursday 6."]

Dear child,

Your Monday letter arrived this morning. I am glad you used ink; it is so easy to read. I am glad you and Anna are having a good time. I see that you went to Waco on Monday. That will teach you to watch out for holidays.

Your package or valise arrived safely. I took out what I wanted—the things I had asked you to send—and sent the rest back on Monday. It served the purpose. I gave Mrs. Henderson the suitcase.

[Scan page 57]

The doctor says my trouble is doing fine, and of course he knows better than I do. I feel first-rate today. I had the blues when I wrote on Monday, in the letter you are reading today.

No, I do not want to put up any beef, much less can any. There is too much risk of poisoning. If Ernest wants to kill one and sell the meat, keeping a small piece for you, that is all right, but I do not think it would pay.

[Scan page 58]

If Bruce wants the car very much, he will get rid of his and buy it. If he does not, someone else will; high-priced cotton will put some money into the country.

I am very sorry to hear of Ira's condition. Whatever happens, that means a great deal of suffering. I am glad Ernest's cotton is turning out so well. There must be some mistake about it. Get an estimate of the whole crop as soon as you can.

[Scan page 59]

My appetite holds up, and I sleep well. Tomorrow I expect to help the doctor make cider. For some reason the apples are falling badly, and these fallen apples yield about two gallons of cider per bushel. The quality is inferior, but it is better than nothing. Good apples sell here for a dollar to a dollar and a half a bushel; cider, fifty cents to a dollar a gallon; pears, \$1.00 to \$1.50 a bushel.

[Scan page 60]

Keep up with your business. If I continue improving and feeling better, there will be no use in your spending money on a trip here. It would wear you out, and I would have to wait on you for a week. The doctor has five patients now. Well, this is enough for this time.

Affectionately,
Papa

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 61–63

Friday morning: hopeful news about healing

Friday, 9 a.m. [No full date or signature is visible in these three pages.]

The last plug has been removed, and no further treatment is intended unless more metastases develop. There is no sign of that this morning. The hole in my cheek, made by the cancer coming out, will take a long time to heal. The process will be slow, but not painful. The pain is practically over; only soreness remains, and that is disappearing. There is less swelling now than when I left home, and less soreness.

[Scan page 62]

The lump under my jaw is gradually becoming smaller, thinner, and flatter, about like a small butter bean. So you can rest easy about me from now on. This morning I certainly feel hopeful of a final cure.

The doctor will not let me do any work because, he says, becoming warm through exercise slows the healing. I make my bed in the morning, wash my handkerchiefs as often as needed, dry dishes for Mrs. Henderson, help string beans, husk roasting ears, and do any little odd job that comes to hand.

[Scan page 63]

Mr. Ridley is steadily improving, but with all the skin gone from the back of his hand, it will take a long time to heal. Mrs. Johnson is progressing very slowly. I do not know whether she has the strength to pull through. I think the cancer has been killed, but her health is bad.

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 64–70

Papa to Zella: repairs to the house and life with Dr. Bird

[Scan page 64: envelope to Zella Douglas, Red Oak, Texas, postmarked Union City, California, September 12. The letter heading reads “Wednesday 11–23”; the date is retained without silently correcting the discrepancy.]

My dear child,

Your Monday letter has just arrived, and I am glad of the favorable report. Perhaps we will have enough to get by on. Healing is going nicely. The only trouble is that I have to keep my jaw still, so I have cut down to two meals a day. I told the doctor I would willingly cut that to once every two or three days if it would help. My general health is as good as ever.

[Scan page 66]

Now, about the old house: I must make my room tighter for winter. Last winter I noticed cold air coming very noticeably through the ceiling joints. There are three ways to stop it: cover the old ceiling with new lumber, paper it, or paint the walls. I leave the repair to you, because I may not be home before cold weather.

The front of the house needs repainting. Painting would be the quickest, and perhaps the cheapest and best, solution. If it is done now, the smell would be gone before cold weather.

[Scan page 67]

The walls need a good coat of oil first to stop the paint peeling. Oil, paint, and labor will probably cost about fifty dollars, though you might get it done more cheaply. Paper might look nicer, but to paper overhead you would have to put ceiling material under the joists. That would make rat havens to beat the band.

[Scan page 68]

Have whoever paints the front of the house clean the gutter in front. It may need new screen wire afterward. Get Ernest to bring enough lumber from the lumberyard for scaffolding. Show him what you want done, and he will know what to get. Previously, all the front painting was done from the long ladder, widened at the bottom. Do you think you can manage this?

[Scan page 69]

I sometimes dry dishes, help string beans, husk roasting ears, and draw an occasional bucket of water. The doctor will not let me do anything that would warm me up, such as gathering apples or making cider. Help is as scarce here as it is there. He cannot get anyone to gather his apples and make cider. White people will not, or do not, work, and Black people are scarce. I do not know when I last saw a white man looking for work. [The original uses a racial slur for Black people. This sentence retains the writer's assertion in modern wording.]

[Scan page 70]

I am sorry you missed Allie. She could have given you an idea of things here. I certainly hope she does not have a breakdown. I fear she will not have the strength for her task.

The doctor has six patients now and may have another next week. Mrs. Johnson is very feeble. The cancer is killed, but the aftereffects of X-rays are almost as bad. I am hurrying to send this so you will get it on Saturday.

Affectionately,
Papa

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 71-77

Papa to Zella: treatment, taxes, and the cotton crop, August 30, 1923

[Scan page 71: envelope to Zella Douglas, Red Oak, Texas, postmarked Union City, California, August 30, 1923.]

August 30, 1923

My dear child,

I am feeling pretty good this morning. Most of the cancer has come out. A little remains, though I cannot tell how much. The doctor thinks a few more treatments will finish the job. The lump under my jaw is going away, apparently getting smaller with each treatment. There is no sign of trouble there yet.

Neither the doctor nor I can say when I will get home. It depends on conditions. If no more trouble develops and I stay until fully healed, it may be the middle of October.

[Scan page 73]

I suppose you have my letter telling you what to do with the Ford and the young cattle, and about saving feed for one cow. Now I want you to go to Mr. Ligon and get the note on the Guaranty Trust Bank of Waxahachie, due September 11. Arrange for him to collect it that day. Do not fail to do this.

Then go to the tax collector's office in Waxahachie, ask for my tax receipt, and pay the taxes by check on Red Oak. Take the receipt to the attorneys Farrar and Kimble and leave it with them. They may need it as evidence in the pending suit over the Ferris taxes.

[Scan page 74]

Tell Boyd Farrar to draw on Red Oak for whatever money he needs as attorney in my case.

When all this is done, write me the amount of the taxes in words, not figures. You cannot make pencil figures legible. I could not tell exactly what the figures in your Dallas letter were; I had to guess, and guesswork will not do in business.

[Scan page 75]

Have Ernest and Van carefully estimate the cotton crop in bales. I must know how it is turning out and the approximate price.

Of course I would be glad to have you here, and glad for you to have the trip for a change, but so far you do not need to come. After Allie leaves in a few days I will be comfortably situated with Dr. Bird. Your trip would cost at least one hundred dollars. If I continue doing all right, there will be no need for it.

[Scan page 76]

Still, you are right to have arrangements ready so that you can come immediately if needed. I sincerely hope it will not be necessary.

Stoker made an awful charge. Did he itemize it? He must have overhauled the whole machine.

Allie is preparing to go to Gunter, take charge of a dormitory, and put the children in school. Considering everything at this particular time, I think this is a very bad move. She has cancer, and going away from the doctor for a year is too great a risk in her case. There is no telling what a year may bring.

[Scan page 77]

There is plenty of rain here. The corn is green and mostly at the good roasting-ear stage. Cotton is said to be good, and so is the boll weevil. Days are warm, eighty to ninety degrees; nights are cool, and I sleep under covers every night.

Duckworth has been made business manager of the A. W. [initials as written]. He has sent a circular to the brethren asking for help to print it. He says he has no money, the paper has none, and he must have help to publish the first issue. If that does not kill it outright, my guess is wrong.

Affectionately,
Papa

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 78–81

Henry to his father: work and church life in Palestine, September 8, 1851

[Scan page 78 labels this letter to N. L. Douglas from his son Henry Douglas, Palestine, Texas, September 8, 1851. A second label says “Letters written by Henry and Ellen Douglas.”]

Palestine, September 8, 1851

Dear Father,

Your letter of August 16 arrived a few days ago. I was very glad to hear from you all again. I had just been writing to Sister Rebecca and scolding her a good deal for not writing to me. From your letter I see that the fault lies entirely with the mail, so I will not send it.

I am glad the family is healthy. It gives me some hope that people can enjoy good health on Brushy as well as elsewhere. Although this county is said to be one of the healthiest in the state, it has been very sickly for the last two months—more so than I ever saw in Ellis or Dallas. I think old Mr. [Ransom?] is nearly willing to try the Brazos again; moving here has not improved his health. There have been many deaths in the county, and the five doctors living here have had their hands full. It is becoming healthier now.

[Scan page 80]

My own health has never been better than since I came here. I still find plenty of work. I stopped working for Mr. Dale about a month ago and have been picking up small jobs around town ever since. If living here were not so expensive, I could make a reasonably good living. I am helping build a large livery stable. My wages are \$1.50 a day, but after paying [ten?] dollars a month for board and washing, considerably less remains.

There should be a very good opening for carpenters here this winter and spring. I am undecided whether to continue working for wages or become an independent contractor; I think I could get plenty to do either way.

The Christian Church here has decided to build a house of worship as soon as lumber can be obtained. It will be forty-six feet long and thirty-four feet wide and should look very neat when finished.

It has been so long since it rained that I have forgotten when it last did. Everything is badly parched. Corn crops are tolerably good, but cotton will not make more than half a crop.

[Scan page 81]

I was at Mr. Mallard's house some time ago. He says he is bound for old Rutherford as soon as he can get away. He and his wife have both been very sick, and he says he cannot stand the climate. He likes the country [a few words are obscured], and says that if he stayed in Texas he would move up to your neighborhood. But his wife is very dissatisfied and will hear of nothing except returning to Tennessee.

I believe I have written everything that might interest you. Nothing pleased me more than hearing of Susannah's obedience to the truth. My sincere prayer is that she remain faithful to the end, and that every member of the family old enough to understand should be gathered into Christ's fold.

I long to see you all. Perhaps I will visit between now and Christmas. Give my love to Mother, my brothers and sisters, and my respects to the neighbors and friends generally; there are too many names to mention. All of you, write and tell me everything. Nothing more at present.

Your affectionate son,
Henry Douglas

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 82–85

Ellen to Lizzie: Christmas visitors and wartime family arrangements, January 12, 1862

[Scan page 82 is an identifying label.]

January 12, 1862

Dear Sister Lizzie,

Your letter arrived last week. Beck was here, and we enjoyed reading it together. It had been some time since we heard from you. We expected some of you at Christmas.

I had plenty of cake and pies at my cabin on Christmas Day, and a big eggnog. I invited some nearby neighbors to dine. About ten o'clock I looked out and saw fourteen young men and girls all dressed up and coming toward us. I had not known they were coming, so they took me by storm. You can be sure the young people here had a lively time all week. Afterward, nearly all the young men left for the war. I wish you and Laura had been here.

I have not been anywhere since Christmas week because I have been sick ever since, and was unwell for a week before. I have chills now and the old ["razer"—word uncertain], as Heath calls it. [Larkin?] had a chill last week and now has very sore eyes. He is walking, is as pretty as any lady's boy, and can now talk as well as Angus. Maggie is growing fast and will be another Sister Fleming.

[Scan page 84]

Maggie's health is good. She is quite hardy, though lean—not as heavy as my man Angus. Angus is as fat as a pig and as full of fights and mischief as he can be.

Beck has not been very well. She stayed with me all week and went home Friday. Warren has gone to [place unclear] to arrange for her to move there. He is going to the war as soon as she has her baby. They will keep house until after that. She expects the baby about February 5 to 10. I am writing this part for Mother, rather than you, because I know she will want to know.

Warren tried to persuade one of Beck's sisters to come home with him and stay with her, but for one reason or another they would not leave home. I do not know whom she will get. I told her I would come if she could find no one else.

We are still in Sam's cabin. I expect to remain here for some time, since there is no sign of work being done on the other house. Tell Sue I am glad her hopes are being realized—that her house has been started. I wish mine were under way. If I can be her neighbor, I will not mind so much having to stay in Sam's cabin. But when Beck leaves, I do not know what I will do up on the [word unclear], with nobody nearby unless someone moves into their house.

[Scan page 85]

Well, I think I have told you about everything. Tell Laura that when I last saw Amanda Berry, she asked after her and said she must write. Lizzie West was here not long ago and also said Laura should write. I believe both claim a letter from her. She must be sure to write to me too.

Is Sue ever coming, or any of you? I reckon you will all come now to see Warren before he leaves. He will go as soon as Beck is well enough for him to move her to her father's. You must come, and all write when you can. My love to Father and Mother, Sue, and the boys.

As ever, your affectionate sister,
Ellen Douglas

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGE 86

Henry's note to his father, January 15, 1862

Waxahachie, January 15, 1862

Dear Father,

I went to Brushy yesterday to see whether I could secure the land near [name blotted out], but failed to get the certificate from him, as I expected. I suppose Ellen and Beck have written all the news. Warren will join the army soon. I do not know when I can come down. We are expecting some of you before Warren starts.

H. Douglas

Additional notes: Warren is likely to leave in February but does not yet know what company he will join. We have not yet put the fence around the field, but will sow wheat. We need rain very much. I sent 752 pounds of wool to Shreveport; it brought twenty cents [apparently per pound, though the unit is not repeated].

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 87-91

Henry to Lizzie: faith, family, and the harvest, September 6, 1892

[Scan page 87 identifies Henry Douglas, Red Oak, Texas, writing to Sister Lizzie, possibly in California.]

Red Oak, Texas, September 6, 1892

Dear Sister Lizzie,

My long delay in replying was not caused by indifference or lack of affection for a dear absent sister. Some of your letter's contents discouraged me. I thought silence easier and wiser than saying something that might do no good. I wish only to express regret—indeed, sorrow—over the worldly condition described in your letter. Surely California is not unlike Sodom and Gomorrah. A day in the Lord's courts is worth a thousand elsewhere. If I were in such a place, I would hurry away lest I too forget God.

[Scan page 89]

“Be ready, for the Son of Man comes at an hour when you do not expect him” is an instruction we must remember. The wicked may forget, but I know nothing more likely to make us forget than love of money, or the worship of Mammon. We have that here. It keeps Christians away from the Lord's house, weakens faith, dulls conscience, and makes us lazy instead of patiently continuing in good works through which we inherit the promises.

We have just had a good meeting at Sylvana, conducted by Brothers [Art?] and Barnes. You will rejoice with me that Clarence and Kate obeyed the gospel. They will be fourteen on the eighth of this month. I trust that when the Lord gathers his jewels, they will be among them.

[Scan page 90]

Also there were your [nephew?] Otis Mangum, Lee Weatherford, Robbie Sullivan, Jessie Graves, Mrs. Ben Patton, and others you do not know. I wish you could have been with us. I hope you will be here for the next meeting.

We are having fine weather and are gathering good corn. Our wheat and oats were fine, and cotton is a good average. Many are picking; the gin whistles are beginning to sound. If we can get fair prices, we will prosper. Mr. Ward has a good crop for you; I think he is a good renter.

Henry Allen plans to move to Hood County near Acton. Sam Strand has rented Mrs. Bell's place. Mrs. [Fretow?] has rented Dr. Duff's, and her son-in-law, [Arsene?] Henry, our place.

[Scan page 91]

Jodie is in poor health as usual and left yesterday for Erath County. Travis County's crops failed this year, and I do not know whether he will return there. Billy Davis fell from his wagon and [was killed?—the words lie on a dark fold] near Palmer about ten days ago. We have otherwise had a very healthy year so far, exceptionally so.

Give my love to Tom, Laura, and their family, and to John and Sarah. I would like to see them all, but appearances deceive me [the connection in this phrase is uncertain]. As the distance to California is long, our time is growing short. Write when you receive this and say when we may expect you home. Sue will probably teach on Brushy this winter, and I will send Kate to her. Give my regards to Mr. and Mrs. Barton.

Your brother,
Henry

SOURCE 04 • FOLDER 1 • SCAN PAGES 92–96

Henry to his mother: delayed journey home and a church meeting, December 1853

[Scan page 92 labels the letter December 30, 1853. The handwritten heading on page 93 appears to read "Dec. 3d 1853," meaning December 3. Both readings are preserved for comparison.]

Palestine, December 3 [label: December 30], 1853

Dear Mother,

Time passes rapidly, and tonight I find myself writing instead of traveling home as I had wished. I often think definite plans for the future are hardly worth making, since mine fail so often. The date of my return is so uncertain that this time I will make no promises. The main reason for the delay is that my expenses have been greater than expected, so I must work longer.

I hoped to see Warren here last week but was disappointed. I did have the pleasure of meeting David Geaslin at Bonner's Ferry on the Trinity last Monday evening and again Tuesday morning. From him I learned some news of home, including that Jesse and Warren had gone out to the Brazos.

[Scan page 94]

I am very much behind on your plans and prospects at home. None of you writes anything definite about them. Warren has written a little about his trip to the Brazos, but referred only casually to a second trip in his last letter. Had I come home now, I suppose I would have had the pleasure of missing both him and Jesse. When I do come, I want them both to be there. Please write immediately and tell me when they will return.

That is all my business for now; I must think of some news. Our meeting closed last Monday night. I think it was very useful and interesting. Because of cold, bad weather, neighboring churches were less fully represented than expected. I think the cooperation will be effective. About \$450 was pledged for evangelism, and with a little effort I believe that amount could be doubled.

[Scan page 95]

A committee of five managers was appointed to employ an evangelist and conduct the cooperation's other business. We hope much good will result in the coming year. Several preachers were confidently expected, but none came, so Brother Kendrick did all the preaching.

Five were baptized, and another person was added to the church. Two of them were little boys: Addilann [name uncertain], Brother Clark's son, about twelve; and Albert, Brother K.'s eldest son, about ten. They seemed fully to understand what they were doing, and I have no doubt they did. It was a beautiful and moving scene: young, comparatively innocent children entering the Kingdom and dedicating their lives to the Redeemer, while old, gray-haired people remained unmoved by the gospel and could not be persuaded to devote what remained of their seventy years to the only cause worth living for and the only one promising anything for the future.

[Scan page 96]

There is considerable sickness in the country, and I occasionally hear of a death. My own health is excellent. My paper is nearly full, and I must close.

I now think I will probably be home around Christmas or early in January. My love to all.

Yours affectionately,
Henry Douglas

Address panel: Mrs. Mary Douglas, Red Oak, Texas. Additional address trials repeat her name; another inscription reads "Mr. Henry Douglas." A small partial closing is too faint to recover fully.